Mohammed leader Masood Azhar as a terrorist by the UN. Thus, in late 2016, anti-Chinese sentiments among the Indian public increased and found an outlet in social media campaigns encouraging the boycott of Chinese manufactured products. For a period, #BoycottChinaProduct and #BoycottChineseGoods gained thousands of tweets, reaching a peak during the autumn festival of Diwali, when sales of gift items, Diwali lights, and firecrackers, all manufactured in China, fell. Chinese exports to India accounted for only 2 percent of the country's total exports, however, and China stated that the boycott was likely to hurt Indian traders and consumers rather than China and to negatively affect bilateral relations and Chinese investments.[61]

When India–Pakistan tensions again flared up in February 2019, with the Pulwama terrorist attack, India retaliated by conducting unprecedented air strikes inside Pakistani territory. Jaish-e-Mohammed claimed responsibility for the attack, re-igniting Indian resentment of China's refusal to act through the UN. In May 2019, when Beijing finally conceded, letting the UN Security Council designate Azhar as a terrorist,[62] Indian analysts claimed a diplomatic victory for New Delhi.[63] Coming halfway through the 2019 Lok Sabha elections, this diplomatic coup could hardly have been timelier for Modi, who was running for a second term in office.

When India in August 2019 abrogated Article 370 in its constitution, which had granted Jammu and Kashmir special status, and created two new Union Territories: Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh, tensions rose again. Strong and immediate reactions came from Pakistan, which expelled the Indian ambassador to Islamabad and downgraded diplomatic ties. China in particular opposed the change in Ladakh's status, arguing it "undermines China's territorial sovereignty," and called for dialogue and restraint.[64] China